USER MANUAL · VERSION 0.1

The Red Thread

A forensic case-analysis tool for adoption investigations. It reads scanned case documents, links the people and organizations in them, builds a timeline, and flags irregularities, with an investigator reviewing every finding before it enters the case.

Alderson OSINT Group LLC

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01

Before you start

How the tool thinks about evidence.

The AI reads; you decide. Every document is read by an AI vision engine, but nothing it finds becomes part of the case until you have checked it against the original and pressed `Commit to Case`. Treat every AI field as a draft.

Originals are never altered. The files you upload are stored as the evidence of record. Rotating a photo is the only operation that rewrites a file, and only before it has been committed.

Language. The tool uses careful, trauma-informed language: it reports *irregularities* and *anomalies*, never conclusions such as "trafficking". A flag is a reason to look closer, not a finding of wrongdoing.

The app's screens are in English. This manual shows button names exactly as they appear on screen, like `Upload Documents`.

02

Installing and first launch

1. Run **The Red Thread_0.1.0_x64-setup.exe** and follow the installer. It installs for your Windows user only; no administrator rights are needed. The installer includes the local AI engine, so no internet connection is required to install or to use the local engine.
2. Open **The Red Thread** from the Start menu or the desktop shortcut. A splash screen appears while the database service and the local AI engine start.
3. The very first launch can take up to a minute while Windows security scans the newly installed programs. Later launches are faster.

> i The first document read by the **local** AI engine after each launch takes longer (often one to two minutes) because the model is loaded into memory. It stays loaded while you work.

03

Protecting your case files (encryption)

Recommended as the first thing you do on a new installation.

With encryption on, the case database, every uploaded document, and your saved AI service keys are encrypted with AES-256 on this computer. Anyone who copies the files without your passphrase sees only scrambled data. The app opens on a lock screen and locks itself when you step away.

Turning encryption on

1. Open `Settings` in the sidebar and scroll to **Security**.
2. Choose a passphrase of at least 10 characters, type it twice, and press `Turn on encryption`. A long phrase of several unrelated words is both strong and memorable.
3. The app encrypts all existing data. This usually takes seconds; very large cases can take a minute. Any unencrypted backup copies the app itself had kept are securely deleted.
4. A **recovery key** is displayed, in the form `ABCD-EFGH-…` (eight groups of four characters). Store it somewhere other than this computer: a password manager, or written on paper and kept somewhere safe.

5 Tick **I have stored this recovery key somewhere safe** and press `Done`. The key is never shown again.

> ! **There is no back door.** If both the passphrase and the recovery key are lost, the case files cannot be recovered by anyone, including the developers. This is what makes the encryption trustworthy.

Locking and unlocking

- **Lock now:** press `Lock` at the bottom of the sidebar, or `Lock now` in Settings → Security.
- **Automatic lock:** after a period without activity (15 minutes by default). Change it in Settings → Security: 5, 15, 30 or 60 minutes, or Never. The app never locks while documents are still being read; it locks once the queue is finished.
- **Unlock:** type the passphrase on the lock screen. After several wrong attempts the app slows down further attempts.

Forgotten passphrase

On the lock screen choose `Forgot the passphrase? Use your recovery key`, enter the recovery key (dashes and capital letters are optional), and choose a new passphrase. The recovery key keeps working afterwards.

Changing the passphrase

Settings → Security → **Change passphrase**: enter the current passphrase and the new one twice. Nothing is re-encrypted, so this is instant. Your recovery key does not change.

> i For complete protection, also turn on Windows **BitLocker** (full-disk encryption) and use a Windows account password. Those protect everything else on the computer too, including temporary files outside the app's control.

04

Creating a case

Every case is built around one **subject**: the person whose adoption is being investigated. The subject is the fixed centre of the case's network map.

1 Press `+ New Case` in the sidebar.

2 Fill in the **case number** (your own reference), a **case title**, and the subject's **full name**. These three are required.

3. Optionally add **aliases** (comma-separated: other names the subject has been known by, such as the name given after adoption), **date of birth**, **place of birth**, and **notes**.
4. Press `Create Case`. The case opens on its Documents tab.

The sample case

To learn the tool or demonstrate it, press `Load sample case` on the New Case page. It creates **Sample Case (fictional)**: invented people, organizations, documents and dates, arranged so that every type of flag appears. It also adds three fictional watchlist entries marked "fictional sample". Delete them from the Investigated Entities page when you no longer need them.

05

Adding documents

Uploading scans and photos

1. In the case's **Documents** tab, press `Upload Documents` and select one or more files. Accepted formats: **JPG, PNG and PDF**.
2. Each file appears in the list with a status badge: **pending** (waiting in the queue), **processing** (being read), **extracted** (ready for your review), **reviewed** (committed), or **error**.
3. Documents are read one at a time, a few seconds apart, so a large batch never overloads the AI engine. You can keep working while they are processed.

Multi-page PDFs are read one page at a time. Up to 40 pages per file are read automatically; if a file is longer, a message tells you which pages to enter by hand.

Phone photos are reduced in size in memory before being sent to the AI. The stored original keeps its full resolution.

Manual entries

For information with no scanned document (a phone call, a public record, something a witness said), press `+ Manual Entry`, give it a label, and fill in the same review form by hand.

Duplicate photos

When the same page has been photographed twice, a **Possible duplicate photos** panel appears above the document list. Press `Compare…` (or click the two thumbnails) to see both copies side by side, with linked `Fit` / `50%` / `100%` zoom and what was read from each. Then choose `Keep left · delete right`, `Keep right · delete left`, or `Not duplicates: keep both`. Deleting always asks a second time and warns you if that copy has already been reviewed. "Not duplicates" is

remembered. Pixel-identical re-uploads can be removed all at once with `Clean up … exact duplicate(s)`, which keeps the earliest upload of each.

Sideways photos

Select the document and press `⟳ Rotate` above the image; the AI then reads it again in the new orientation. Rotation is available for images (not PDFs) and only before the document is committed.

06

Reviewing and committing

The most important step: checking the AI's reading against the original.

Select a document. The **viewer** in the middle shows the original; the **review panel** on the right shows what the AI found, as editable fields.

Using the viewer

- Images open fitted to the panel. Use `−` and `+` (or **Ctrl + mouse wheel**) to zoom from 5% to 400%, `Fit` to see the whole page, and `100%` for actual size. Scroll to move around a zoomed page.
- PDFs open in the built-in PDF viewer.

The review fields

- **Document Type**: petition, decree, birth certificate, payment receipt, correspondence, medical record, immigration record, court record, or other.
- **Names**: every person and organization on the page, with their role. Correct misspellings, remove anything that is not a real person or organization, and add names the AI missed.
- **Dates**: each with a label (*birth, petition_filed, decree_issued, payment, document_date, other*). See below.
- **Financial Transactions**: amount, currency, what it was for, and any case or file number written next to it.
- **Legal References**: law and decree numbers, comma-separated.
- **Notes**: the AI's short description of the page.

How dates are handled

Dates are converted to a standard form however the document writes them: `24/08/1983`, `24 de agosto de 1983`, `August 24, 1983`, or spelled out in words in notarial style. Under each date the original wording is shown as **As written: "…"**.

A date with an **amber border** needs your attention. The note under it says why:

- **Ambiguous**: `03/04/1985` could be 3 April or 4 March. It is read in the Chilean day/month order; check it if the document is from the United States.
- **Two-digit year**: `85` was read as 1985.
- **No year written**: "May 22nd" took its year from the document's own date line. Confirm against the page.
- **Unreadable or incomplete**: the field is left empty. The app never invents a missing day, month or year; enter it yourself if the page shows it.

Editing a date clears its warning, because you have now checked it.

PDF page tags

For PDFs, every name, date and payment has a page tag such as `p.3`. Click it to jump the viewer to that page.

Committing

When the fields match the original, press `Commit to Case`. Only then are actors, timeline events, network links and flags created, and the score recalculated. Names are matched against existing actors, so spelling variants of the same person are merged rather than duplicated.

To correct a committed document, press `Edit`. This removes its contributions from the case until you commit it again.

`↻ Re-run AI extraction` (top of the review panel, before commit) reads the document again from scratch: useful after an AI service outage or after changing the AI engine. It replaces the unreviewed fields, so it asks you to confirm.

The small line **Read by ...** records which AI engine and model read the document, as part of its provenance.

Starting a case's analysis over

`↻ Re-read all…` (next to `+ Manual Entry`) keeps every uploaded file, the subject profile, case notes and the watchlist, clears everything derived from earlier readings (names, actors except the subject, timeline, links and flags), and reads every document again. Each document then needs your review and `Commit to Case` again. A summary of what will happen is shown before anything changes.

07

The case workspace

Documents

Upload, review and commit, as described above.

Network Map

Every actor as a node, linked to the subject at the centre. Colour by **watchlist** tier, by **role**, or by your own **custom** colours. Click a bubble to see who they are, every reviewed document naming them (under any spelling, with their role and page), their watchlist match and flags, and to choose their colour. In Custom mode, people without a custom colour keep their watchlist colour.

Timeline

Every dated event from committed documents in date order. The same event recorded by several documents is one row ("Recorded in N documents"); expand it to see each source. `Exclude` keeps noise (such as the issue date of certified copies) on record but out of the timeline flags. `Clean up…` previews, then applies, re-dating and re-labelling of events read before the current rules.

Actors

The deduplicated list of people and organizations. Edit names, roles, notes and colours. `Merge Duplicate Actors` suggests pairs that look like the same person; you approve each merge.

Financial

Every payment recorded in reviewed documents: payment date, amount and currency as written, what it was for, any case number written nearby (highlighted when it differs from this case's), and the source page. Totals are kept per currency, never converted. Payments that raised a financial flag are highlighted.

Discrepancies

The same fact (subject name, birth, petition and decree dates) as recorded by each document, side by side. Conflicting values are highlighted. Dates are compared by the day they denote, not by how they are written.

Flags & Score

Every irregularity raised, with its severity and source, and the weighted score. A flag raised by many documents is shown once ("raised by N documents"). `Recompute` recalculates on demand.

Analysis

An AI-written summary and hypotheses about what may have happened, in English or Spanish, drawn only from the reviewed record (see below).

Statements

Evidence that isn't a scanned document. **Testimony** records what a person said (who, their relationship to the case, when, how it was obtained, whether they witnessed it first-hand, and whether it is corroborated). A **verified finding** records something you established and how, such as a DNA test or a registry search. Link each entry to the documents it supports or contradicts and to the people it concerns, and choose whether it raises a flag. Entries are cited in the AI analysis (testimony is treated as what someone said, not as proof) and included in the PDF and JSON exports. Flags raised here are marked "raised by investigator" and do not change the score, which is based on the documents alone.

Notes

Free-form case notes, saved automatically as you type.

Export

PDF report and JSON data export (section 11).

08

Flags and the irregularity score

What raises each flag

FLAG	SEVERITY	RAISED WHEN
Pre-Birth Petition Anomaly	CRITICAL	An adoption petition is dated before the subject's recorded birth.
Timeline Irregularity	CRITICAL	Fewer than 30 days between the recorded birth and the decree.
Financial Anomaly	HIGH	A document describes a payment "por adopción", or a payment is linked to a case number other than this case's own.
Contradiction	MEDIUM	The same fact is recorded differently in two or more committed documents.
Legal Reference	MEDIUM	A document cites Decree 2465 (1979) or Law 18703, in English or Spanish spelling (e.g. "Decreto Ley 2.465", "Ley N° 18.703"). This marks the document for legal review; it is not itself a finding of a violation.
Watchlist Match	BY TIER	An actor matches a watchlist entry: RED → critical, ORANGE → high, YELLOW → medium.

How the score is calculated

The **Case Irregularity Score** runs from 0 to 100. Each flag adds points to its category by severity (critical 50, high 30, medium 18, low 8), with each category capped at 100. The categories are then weighted:

CATEGORY	WEIGHT	INCLUDES
Entity match	35%	Watchlist matches
Timeline	25%	Timeline irregularities and pre-birth petitions
Financial	20%	Financial anomalies
Contradictions	15%	Contradictions between documents
Legal	5%	Legal references

The score is recalculated after every commit, edit, merge or watchlist import. It measures how many documented irregularities a case contains; it is a way to prioritize review, not a conclusion. Only reviewed (committed) documents raise flags, and the same date recorded by several documents counts once.

Case analysis (hypotheses)

On the **Analysis** tab, choose English or Español and press `Generate analysis` (one to three minutes). The AI provider chosen in Settings reads the reviewed case record and returns:

- **Summary** and **established facts**, each with source tags such as `D4` (document), `E12` (timeline event), `F2` (flag), `A3` (actor) or `X1` (discrepancy). Hover over a tag to see the record line it refers to.
- **Hypotheses** about what may have happened, each with evidence for it, evidence against it or left unexplained, possible benign explanations, a conservative confidence rating, and what would confirm or refute it.
- **Gaps** in the record, **recommended next steps**, and **data quality notes**.

Every source tag is checked against the record after the analysis is written; any reference to something not in the record is removed and the statement is marked as unsupported. Each saved analysis keeps the date, the model, and the exact record it was based on (`Show record analysed`), with its fingerprint. Only reviewed documents are included, and the case record is sent as text to the AI provider chosen in Settings (Claude, Grok, OpenAI, Gemini or another provider). The analysis needs a cloud AI; it is not available with the local engine.

> ! An analysis is a set of investigative leads, not evidence, not a legal finding and not a conclusion that anyone did wrong. It carries this disclaimer permanently. Verify every statement against the original documents.

09

The watchlist

The **Investigated Entities** page (sidebar) holds your private list of people and organizations from previous investigations. Every actor in every case is compared against it, tolerating spelling variations and scanning errors.

TIER	INTENDED FOR
RED	Primary facilitators with direct, documented involvement (for example attorneys, judges, agencies).
ORANGE	Recurring secondary participants (for example brokers, foster placements, clinics and hospitals named across several cases).
YELLOW	Organizations worth tracking (for example receiving agencies abroad, religious orders).

- **Add:** enter the name and type, choose a tier, press `Add`.
- **Remove:** press `Remove` next to the entry.
- **Export / import:** `Export list (JSON)` saves the whole list to a file; `Import list…` adds entries from such a file, skipping names already on the list and re-checking every case for new matches. Use this to move your list to another computer.

> ! The watchlist names real people. A new installation starts with an empty list. Exported list files are **not encrypted**: store and share them as carefully as the case files themselves.

10

AI engines, privacy and cost

Choose the engine in `Settings` → **AI Vision Provider**.

ENGINE	WHERE DOCUMENTS GO	QUALITY AND SPEED
Claude (recommended)	Each page image is sent over an encrypted connection to Anthropic to be read.	Most accurate on dense Spanish and English legal documents. About 10 seconds per page. Requires an internet connection and an API key; costs a small amount per page.
Ollama (local)	Nothing leaves this computer.	Works offline at no cost. Less complete on dense documents, so review its results with extra care. Slower, especially the first page after launch.
Grok / OpenAI / Gemini	Sent to xAI, OpenAI or Google respectively.	Alternatives; each needs its own API key. Choose a model that accepts images.
Other AI (OpenRouter, Mistral, DeepSeek, Groq, local server...)	Sent to the service address you enter.	Any OpenAI-compatible service. Use `Test connection` after saving the address, key and model.

- **Fallback:** if the selected cloud engine fails (no internet, invalid key), the document is read by the local engine instead. It is never sent to a cloud service you did not select.
- **API keys** are entered in Settings and are never displayed again after saving. With encryption on, they are stored inside the encrypted vault.
- **For investigations where nothing may leave the computer**, select Ollama (local).

11

Exporting and backing up

Exports

- `Download PDF Report`: subject profile, actors and watchlist matches, timeline, discrepancies, flags and the score breakdown, formatted for a lawyer, an NGO or an investigator.
- `Download JSON Export`: the complete case as structured data, for archiving or for other analysis tools.

> ! Exported files are ordinary, **unencrypted** files. Handle them as sensitive case material.

Where your data lives

Everything is stored in `%APPDATA%\RedThread` (type that into the File Explorer address bar). It contains the case database, the `uploads` folder with the documents, and, with encryption on, `vault.json`,

which holds the encrypted keys.

Backing up

1. Close The Red Thread.
2. Copy the whole `RedThread` folder to an external drive or a secure location.

With encryption on, the backup stays encrypted and opens only with your passphrase or recovery key. Always copy the whole folder: the database and documents cannot be decrypted without `vault.json`. To restore, close the app and put the folder back in the same place.

12

Troubleshooting

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
A dialog says the AI engine could not start	Press Retry. Antivirus software sometimes holds a newly installed program for a moment. If it persists, restart the computer.
The first document takes a long time	Normal for the local engine after launch (model loading). Later documents are faster.
Fields are empty and a yellow warning says the AI could not read the document	Check the internet connection and the API key in Settings, then press `↻ Re-run AI extraction`. You can also fill in the fields by hand.
A PDF uploaded with an earlier version shows empty fields	Earlier versions did not read PDFs. Press `↻ Re-run AI extraction`.
"PDF is password-protected"	Remove the password with a PDF tool and upload it again.
A date is outlined in amber	Read the note under it and check the date against the page (section 06).
The app went back to the lock screen	It locked automatically after inactivity. Enter your passphrase; nothing is lost.
Forgotten passphrase	Use the recovery key on the lock screen (section 03).